

I Chose This Mountain Myself

Halfway across China, on another mountain, I recognized the grasses of home

by Jin Rundi

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Grew up in the mountains of Fang County, Hubei. At seventeen she left home with twenty yuan in her pocket and went on to travel half of China. A nationally certified nutritionist, her work has to do with the body. Today she lives on Wutong Mountain in Shenzhen, where she runs Yungu Retreat: tea, books, and plants.

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Halfway across China, on another mountain, I recognized the grasses of home

After I moved up the mountain, I often walked down along the stream in the mornings.

One day, halfway down, I crouched.

In a crack between the rocks grew a clump of leaves, reddish underneath, with a fishy smell when you pinched them off: fish mint. A few steps on: wild mint, spiderwort, sedge, sow thistle.

Every one of them grew along the creeks back home.

I left that creek when I was seventeen.

01 Twenty yuan and a plastic bag

The summer I was seventeen, I decided to leave home.

Why I left, I won't write here.

I hadn't meant to go. The year I finished school, my plan was to stay: raise fish, raise pigs. Back then there was money in fish and pigs.

That road was not the one I took.

There was no phone at home. I wrote to a classmate and asked her to find me work in town. I mailed the letter and waited many days.

She really did find something: a temp job at a factory in Shiyan.

I wasn't eighteen yet and couldn't get an ID card, so I got a temporary one.

The day I left, I walked out of the room that had been converted from the village grain mill, carrying a plastic bag, twenty yuan in my pocket, her letter in my hand. The minibus from Fang County to Shiyan took several hours.

I had never left that village before. Not because I didn't want to; I was still in school.

As the bus drove out of the mountains, I didn't look back.

I wasn't thinking about where I was going. I was thinking about not coming back.

02 The mountain wasn't scenery. It was work.

That mountain was actually good.

Wild hawthorn, wild grapes, wild peaches, bamboo shoots and azaleas in spring, mushrooms in autumn. There was always something to gather under the larches. In winter it was warmer inside the woods than outside. All year round that mountain was never empty.

But as a child I didn't see it that way.

I went up the mountain to work, to cut grass for the pigs. Alone, and very scared. I ran into snakes many times, and rabbits and pheasants too. Every mountain child knows which stretch of path to hurry along and which things you must not reach for.

The first things I ever learned to know were the plants on that mountain. Their names, which slope they grew on, which month they came up: I could count them off with my eyes closed.

But when I left, I didn't mean to take a single one with me.

The mountain wasn't scenery to me. It was work.

So when I left, I headed for what lay beyond the mountains. The cities were out there, the money was out there; I thought everything I wanted was out there.

03 The signature I gave for someone else

Once I was out, I did everything. Factory work, learning a trade, later my own shop; in the beauty industry I rose all the way to national director, and at my busiest I led a big team.

In those years I held one conviction: if I was good enough to people, people would be good to me.

In 2021, a man I had known for two years through a business association asked me to take out a loan in my own name to help him through a cash crunch. I signed.

I never saw a cent of that money. In the end I repaid every cent of it myself.

I hired a lawyer. He looked at the case and said it was a sure win. Not a cent came back; the legal fees, though, were very real.

For a while I couldn't sleep at night. I shut myself away and didn't want to see anyone.

Then my teacher, Teacher Han, said one sentence: "You have kindness, but not wisdom." It woke me from my confusion.

I had known that man for two years and didn't even know where he lived. I never checked on him; it never occurred to me to. I always thought handing over my heart was the simplest way.

04 Yellow wine poured into soy milk

During the hardest stretch, I had no heart for work; one setback after another, money was tight. My teacher said, go to Mount Wutai and be still for a while. Travel costs money, but I went anyway. I went with my teeth clenched.

I went up Mount Wutai twice and lived on the mountain for days when I barely saw the sun or moon, and I found my real strength.

Coming down, something in me loosened: the pits I had fallen into could not all be blamed on other people.

After that I studied the I Ching and feng shui with Master Xie Shimin and traveled with him to many places. In those years I walked all over Jiangxi.

Once, in Sanliao village, I ate something new: yellow wine poured into soy milk, and the soy milk turned into tofu pudding.

My mother made tofu her whole life. Dried tofu cured in wood ash, fermented tofu that kept all summer. I watched her all through my childhood and had never seen it done this way.

That day, I walked out from the far side of the Yin-Yang River in Sanliao, the birthplace of feng shui, sat down, and finished that

bowl of tofu pudding. I still had the bag with my compass on my back, a red scarf around my neck; autumn in Jiangxi was a little cool.

I had walked for decades and thousands of miles, and in someone else's village I came upon another way of doing what my mother did.

05 I didn't speak up

In these years of seeking the Way, what I have done most is subtract.

In the beauty industry I had made it to national director, and I simply stopped.

In recent years I've turned down even more. Business alliances, salons, all kinds of outside events: I don't go to any of them. There was a camp I ran for several years; it was exhausting, so I stopped. Anything that makes me tired, I stop.

Not long ago there was someone whose situation I understood, and I knew I could help.

In the past I would have spoken up long before. All my life I was the one who rushed to speak first.

That time, I didn't.

Someone told me to let things take their course. I said there is no illness that cannot be treated, only people who cannot be saved.

Without blessings you meet a poor doctor; without virtue you meet a false teacher.

Your kindness is not something everyone can receive.

This year brought another change: when something comes up, I no longer go straight to someone to ask. I first talk it through with AI from the beginning, and only once it's clear do I speak. It used to be the other way around: I'd ask people first and still be confused afterwards.

06 The same plants grow by the creeks back home

Someone else brought me up Wutong Mountain.

I needed to hold an event in Shenzhen and wanted somewhere natural and beautiful. A friend who lived on the mountain said, come and take a look. He walked me down that street, then along that stream.

Later, holding events on the mountain, hauling things up and down was too tiring, so I thought I'd simply find a permanent place here.

The day I went to see the place, the first thing I looked at wasn't the house. It was the mountain.

On my first morning living there, the first thing I did was walk by the stream.

This mountain is different from the one I grew up on. Here the leaves are big and there are more flowers; back home it was larches, with mushrooms everywhere beneath them.

But those few plants along the creek are exactly the same.

Now when I go up the mountain I don't gather herbs anymore. When I see one I like, I dig it up and plant it at the door of Yungu. The last

one I brought back is growing well; cut a sprig or two and put them in a vase, and they look lovely.

This mountain is not that mountain; this river is not that river.

That mountain is the place that gave me life.

This mountain is the place I chose myself, to nourish me.

This mountain is not that mountain; this river is not that river.

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